

Q Will I be able to see my baby being born during the surgery?

In order to spare you unnecessary trauma, nurses will construct a screen between you and your belly so that you can't see your doctor cut through your skin and into your uterus.

However, you can usually ask for the screen to be lowered enough so that you can see your baby lifted out. The screen will be removed as soon as you've been stitched up.

Q Will my doctor be in the OR with me? Who else will be there?

Yes, your doctor will perform your C-section and be present with you throughout the procedure. Also expect to have an anesthesiologist present, as well as a labor and delivery nurse, who can offer reassurance to both you and your birth partner and answer questions as they may arise. There may also be a technician present to assist the doctor. And there should be a pediatrician or neonatologist for the baby—or one doctor for each baby, if you're having multiples. All in all, the operating room can get quite busy!

Q Can my birth partner come into the operating room (OR) with me?

One birth partner is usually allowed into the operating room as long as you are having a spinal anesthetic or an epidural. He or she will need to wear a surgical gown and a surgical mask, but will be allowed to sit beside you as you have your surgery. If you have general anesthesia, you will usually not be permitted to have anyone in OR with you (you'll be completely asleep). Your birth partner will be able to wait just outside the operating room.

Q I am HIV positive. Will I have to have a C-section?

No. The most recent guidelines from the US National Institutes of Health (NIH) recommend that women who are HIV positive and on medication that is controlling the effects of the virus are given the option of having a vaginal delivery. Overall, studies show that there is no increased risk to the baby of contracting the virus by vaginal rather than C-section. Your doctor will be able to advise you in your specific circumstances.

Q If the only reason for having a C-section is because my labor is taking a long time, can I refuse?

Yes, although your doctor gives his or her advice with your best interests in mind, so you should ask why he or she is suggesting the procedure, what it involves, and what would happen if you don't opt for it. Consider the risks carefully before you decide. If you choose to refuse medical intervention, your doctor will respect your wishes. They will continue to work to ensure the best outcome for you and your baby in any circumstances.

Q Who will take care of my baby if I have to have general anesthesia?

Assuming all is well with your baby after birth, that's really a decision for you—let your doctor know your preference before you go into surgery, if possible. As a default, your birth partner will be encouraged to hold and cuddle with your baby until you wake up, to have skin-to-skin contact if that is you want, and to bottle feed her if necessary.

Cesarean births With an epidural or spinal anesthetic, you're awake at the moment of delivery and can see and hold your baby immediately.

